

Back on track

McLaren continues its dominance with **back-to-back wins** by Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri.

Kavita Menon

kavita.menon@thehindu.co.in

Norris cruises to victory at Monaco

On this track, racing often takes a back seat. This year, it wasn't too different as the spectacle once again became a contest of patience and precision. On a circuit where overtaking is negligible, and there is more focus on pit strategy than pure pace, victory is decided long before the chequered flag — during qualifying.

And on Saturday, Lando Norris delivered a lap that's worthy of Monaco folklore, snatching pole from hometown hero Charles Leclerc by the finest of margins. In Monaco — a place Norris now calls home — something shifted.

Coming into the eighth round, Norris had trailed his McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri in both form and fortune. After winning in Melbourne, his season became a frustrating string of near-misses — podiums and points aplenty — but a win remained elusive.

Even his sprint victory in Miami came under the shadow of a well-timed Safety Car. Each weekend chipped away at his confidence, and he admitted to the struggle. The pressure of expectation, both internal and external, was beginning to bite. He finally caught a break and received a much-needed push in Monaco.

The FIA's introduction of a mandatory two-stop rule aimed to add some excitement, but the status quo at Monaco remained intact. Over the 78 laps, the pit wall chess match defined the race. Teams strategically delayed the grid for pitting, bluffed tyre choices, and built significant gaps to gain advantages.

An improbable team game took centre stage, and perfectly managed stints mattered more than bold overtakes. An unpredictable element was added to the



Two-way drama: Lando Norris (above) and Oscar Piastri (right) won the Monaco and Spanish Grand Prix. REUTERS & AFP

monotony of the Monegasque event, yet not much changed. But rising above it all was Norris, who had revived himself once again, snatching his first win since the season opener in Australia. Shaky off the line but sharp thereafter, he didn't put a wheel wrong and absorbed pressure from a determined Ferrari, leaving no room for error.

Leclerc, who has endured a love-hate relationship with his home race, kept the pressure high throughout, but could not make it a second fairytale victory in a row in front of his people. Piastri rounded off the podium.

The result reignited Norris' title challenge and McLaren's hold on the top two of the standings. In his redemption drive, he realised a dream — to win in Monaco, the crown jewel of Formula 1 and the race every driver wants to conquer. In doing so, Norris reminded the world, and perhaps himself, that he still belongs at the very top.



MotoGP



The British MotoGP event witnessed the younger Marquez brother, Alex (right), cruise to sprint victory, while a surprise new race winner from Aprilia gave the team its first win in more than a year.

At the Silverstone circuit, Fabio Quartararo impressed with his single-lap pace once again and stormed to pole, pipping Marc Marquez. But his glorious lead lasted one lap in the sprint before the Spaniard overtook him to get back on course.

However, the older Márquez made a rare mistake, running wide on the second lap and handing the prized position to Alex, who had passed